



Spanish Soccer League LALIGA's Digital Transformation

Case Study

This case was written by **Dr. Garima Ratna** and reviewed by **Dr. A. Saravanan Naidu**, Amity Research Centers Headquarter, Bangalore. It is intended to be used as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a management situation. The case was compiled from published sources.

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*"It's not football. It's La Liga"*¹

– Campaign Slogan of LALIGA

*"With the foundation of soccer being the number one sport worldwide, with over four billion fans, the Spanish league is an interesting field of study. Today, soccer is not only a game. Soccer is also entertainment, and it has become a billion-dollar business."*²

– Excerpt from a Working Paper by Stephen A. Greyser, et al.

LALIGA, the Spanish football league, had come a long way since its formation in 1929. It grew to become world's second (Opta Power Rankings: 2024) with the English Premier League (EPL) occupying the topmost position. With the progression of time, LALIGA became bigger and better with 20 clubs under its fold, two prominent and crowd pulling being Real Madrid and Barcelona. A major turning point came when Javier Tebas (Tebas) became the President of LALIGA and his focus on technology and international expansion became the two pillars of LALIGA's stupendous growth. Under Tebas' leadership, LALIGA spread its wings across 41 countries through its 13 offices and 44 delegates. His technology push strategy entailed three components: Content Enhancement, Competition Management and Fan Engagement. Tebas transformed LALIGA from just being a Spanish league to a global sports business powerhouse that focused on 'fan experience' and overall growth of football. In the process, LALIGA diversified its revenue streams with TV and broadcasting rights, content streaming, offering consultancy and training to other clubs, etc. However, despite all this, LALIGA could not surpass EPL's status, be it in terms of financial health or fan reach. What were the reasons behind it? Was LALIGA's digital transformation not yielding desired outcomes or was it too early to say?

LALIGA: The Spanish Soccer League

Campeonato Nacional de Liga de Primera División, widely known as LALIGA, was the famous Spanish football league established in 1929. According to sports historians, prior to LALIGA, there was another soccer league in Spain namely the Catalan football championship (Campionat de Catalunya). This league was established in 1901. When LALIGA was founded,

¹ "The new global campaign – It's not football. It's LaLiga", <https://www.laliga.com/en-GB/news/campana>, November 13th 2017

² Greyser A. Stephen, et al., "LALIGA - From a Soccer Competition Organizer to a Global Player in the Sports and Entertainment Industry", https://www.hbs.edu/ris/Publication%20Files/24-009_2c6ecf1b-a325-4101-8a04-a186b6dbdeca.pdf, 2023

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the two leagues operated parallel to each other till 1940 when the Catalan football championship was annulled.

In 1929, the first season of LALIGA happened from February to June. At this time, LALIGA had only one division named, Primera División, which was composed of ten clubs. The number of clubs increased gradually till it became 20 in 1987. The count remained at 20 since then except for the time span between 1995 and 1997 when the number of clubs rose to 22. As of 2024, the LALIGA system had four divisions across four tiers.³ (**Exhibit I**).

Exhibit I
LALIGA's Tier System (2024)

Club	Tier
Primera División (La Liga)	1
Segunda División	2
Segunda División B	3
Tercera División	4

Source: "Spanish La Liga", <https://www.footballhistory.org/league/la-liga.html>

Over the years, LALIGA grew to become a global entity in the world of professional sports. Quoting from the league's website, "LALIGA is a global, innovative and socially responsible organisation, a leader in the leisure and entertainment sector. It is a private sports association composed of the 20 clubs and SADs (public limited sports companies) in LALIGA EA SPORTS and the 22 in LALIGA HYPERMOTION, responsible for the organisation of these national professional football competitions." LALIGA was headquartered in Madrid and was spread across '41 countries through its 13 offices and 44 delegates'. During 2019/2020 season, LALIGA reached out to a robust fan following of over 2.8 billion people across the globe. In addition, as of 2024, LALIGA was in three strategic joint-venture partnerships that included, LALIGA North America and LALIGA Mexico (both in collaboration with RELEVANT), LALIGA China (in collaboration with Mediapro and Super Sports). LALIGA was also involved with women soccer (since 2015), had established LALIGA Business School, was engaged in e-Sports space, had established LALIGA Grassroots, and was involved in the business of sports through LALIGA Entertainment.⁴

With the progression of time, LALIGA became one of the most popular leagues in the world. As of March 2024, it was ranked second in Opta Power Rankings⁵ list; the top one being the English Premier League.⁶ (**Exhibit II**). It was one of the most watched (2.5 billion viewers in 2019-20 season) too.⁷

³ "Spanish La Liga", <https://www.footballhistory.org/league/la-liga.html>

⁴ "What is LALIGA?", <https://www.laliga.com/en-GB/pressroom/what-is-laliga>

⁵ The Opta Power Rankings were a global team ranking system that assigned an ability score over 13,000 domestic football teams on a scale between zero and 100, where zero was the worst-ranked team in the world and 100 was the best team in the world.

⁶ Furniss Matt, et al., "The Strongest Leagues in World Football: How the Opta Power Rankings Can Help", <https://theanalyst.com/eu/2024/03/the-strongest-leagues-in-world-football-opta-power-rankings/>, March 27th 2024

⁷ Wright Sean, "10 most watched soccer leagues", <https://www.redbull.com/us-en/most-watched-soccer-leagues>, October 31st 2022

Exhibit II
Opta Power Rankings (March 2024)



Source: Furniss Matt, et al., “The Strongest Leagues in World Football: How the Opta Power Rankings Can Help”, <https://theanalyst.com/eu/2024/03/the-strongest-leagues-in-world-football-opta-power-rankings/>, March 27th 2024

Analysts identified some factors which made LALIGA so popular and successful. From scoring maximum goals (game enthusiasts loved a high scoring game/season) and the presence of the star players like Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo to something known as ‘El Clasico’ (game between rivals Real Madrid and Barcelona), LALIGA offered everything to soccer fans.⁸ The experts from the Johan Cruyff Institute explained the success of LALIGA thus, “Football is a fertile field and LaLiga has been able to sow its seeds very well in order to grow the business. It bet on a change of mentality and nourished itself with talent to create an international network composed of 44 country managers in 41 different countries that export the Spanish football model; it centralized the television rights to broadcast matches halfway around the world and expanded the business and reach of the league itself and its teams; and where 40 employees used to work, they now have more than 700. Not to mention that they have gone from four million fans on social networks to 100 million in less than eight years.”

A section of analysts believed that LALIGA’s prospects changed when Javier Tebas (Tebas) became its President in 2013. This fact was admitted by José Moya (Moya), Director of LALIGA Business School. Once, in response to questions related to LALIGA’s success, Moya had acknowledged, “I think it was an important moment when Javier Tebas, the current president, arrived to LaLiga. He became the president in April 2013 and he totally changed the mentality. We started to work in a different way and built the brand from the actives we have, players and football teams and now LaLiga as a product is more than just players; it’s a competition, it’s an entertainment, as I said before, and we have been growing from Spain to the planet. Another important date was when we created the project ‘LaLiga global network’, promoted in 2016. We recruited talent from different parts of the world, young people who love sport and

⁸ Field Oliver, “8 Reasons La Liga Is World's Best League”, <https://bleacherreport.com/articles/1876668-8-reasons-la-liga-is-worlds-best-league>, December 9th 2013

football, and we sent them to all over the world as a country manager. We have more than 50 people working for LaLiga in different parts of the world.”⁹

The LALIGA Global Network program was officially rolled out in 2016 with an aim to offer young Spanish men an opportunity to work in the best league of the world. Explaining the recruitment process and the job profile of the recruits, Tebas said, “Their first task will be to liaise with broadcast rights-holders in the countries where they are posted. They will also have to be in contact with non-rights-holding broadcasters to increase LaLiga's presence with them. Their third role will be to build a close relationship with the media in order to improve Spanish football's visibility. Of course, they will also have to be in touch with local leagues and federations in the respective countries and to seek local sponsors to further LaLiga's economic growth.”¹⁰ The program worked and while celebrating its fifth anniversary in 2022, LALIGA Executive Director Óscar Mayo (Óscar) had this to say, “Five years ago, we embarked on an ambitious mission to bring the entertainment and emotion of LaLiga to more fans around the world and to help grow football as a sport everywhere. We are very proud that LaLiga and its main protagonists, clubs, players, coaches, are closer today to more people around the world than ever before. That said, this is just the beginning, together with clubs and with the support of our new partner CVC we will give our international efforts a massive boost.” It was to be noted that the private equity firm CVC had huge investments in LALIGA. There were statistics which affirmed the success of LALIGA Global Network program. By 2022, LALIGA had 146 million followers from across the globe, was connecting with the fan base in more than ‘20 languages across 17 different social media platforms’. The Spanish football was being ‘discussed and debated’ around the world. Going by media reports, from 2020 to 2022, the number of worldwide activations organised by LALIGA doubled (it was close to 1,222). These were spread across more than 90 countries. Also, owing to its global network program, LALIGA had 37 agreements with leagues, federations, and other institutions in over 28 countries. In addition to that, LALIGA had nearly ‘24 educational alliances with international partners from 24 countries through LaLiga Business School’.¹¹

Moya threw more light on LALIGA's success strategy. While defining LALIGA's international strategy as ‘glocal strategy’, Moya added, “Every country is different and they have their own culture, their own way to do things and we learn from all of them. That's why this project, LaLiga global network, is valuable also for LaLiga, because we have information about the whole planet every day, we have reports from all of them. Our model is a sample not only for the sports industry in the world, but also for other industries. What LaLiga is achieving these years, in the past 8, it's something that not many companies in the world have done. We totally changed the mentality, we have passed from, let's say, a national mentality to a global one and we have grown as a company also in people.”¹² According to Óscar, “When it comes to football fans outside of Spain, we always say that we would like to be everyone's second most popular league, after their local league. National leagues are the true engine of football and that's why LaLiga is sharing the recipe of its own success with leagues, federations and clubs around the world.”¹³

⁹ “LaLiga is a good case study as a business model”, <https://johancruyffinstitute.com/en/blog-en/football-business/laliga-is-a-good-case-study-as-a-business-model/>, October 26th 2020

¹⁰ “LaLiga Global Network is born”, <https://www.laliga.com/en-GB/news/laliga-global-network-is-born>, November 7th 2016

¹¹ “Five years of LaLiga's international expansion with record growth”, <https://newsletter.laliga.es/global-futbol/five-years-of-laligas-international-expansion-with-record-growth>, January 31st 2022

¹² “LaLiga is a good case study as a business model”, op.cit.

¹³ “Five years of LaLiga's international expansion with record growth”, op.cit.

Moya stressed upon the importance of branding of the league. While stressing that branding helped fetch better returns, Moya said, "Of course, the international TV rights negotiation and agreements are the main income for LaLiga, but we also have sponsors and international agreements, which is not money but is really good an amazing brand all over the world. And this is the way. TV rights is the result of the audience you have, the fans, but you have to work day by day to have a better audience. More branding means more fans; more fans means more audience. This is the equation and we have to be working on this every day." Moya also stressed upon the contribution of innovation and technology towards LALIGA's success and global reach.¹⁴ For instance, according to an article in LALIGA's newsletter published in January 2022, "The viewing experience is another core element in LaLiga's global reach. In the past years, LaLiga has invested significantly in an ever-improving viewer experience with technology such as drones, skycams and volumetric video powering 360-degree replays, all this delivered through an always growing and improving roster of broadcaster partners." The aforementioned efforts and global outreach strategies fetched the league impressive returns. To quote some figures, there was a 30% hike (Time frame: 2015/16 to 2022) in global audiences for LALIGA matches and a whopping 247% rise (Time frame: 2013/14 to 2022) in the value of the league's international audiovisual rights.¹⁵ In other words, innovation and technology were the cornerstones of LALIGA's global reach and success. Towards this aim, LALIGA began its digital transformation with the launch of LALIGA Tech.¹⁶

Will LaLiga's Digital Transformation Disrupt Professional Sports?

LALIGA's tryst with technology began somewhere around October 2021 when it officially launched LALIGA Tech.¹⁷ In fact, LALIGA Tech was the fruition of several years of investment and prioritisation of technology integration into sports. The concept of integrating technology into sports and driving growth began in LALIGA when Tebas assumed the office of President in 2013. Technology into sports was Tebas' focus area. Under his leadership, LALIGA partnered with Microsoft and an American software company Databricks to develop a 'new data-led technology'. It took almost 10 years of 'technological progression' before LALIGA Tech could take shape.¹⁸ Further, the partnership with Microsoft was aimed at delivering innovation in sports industry on three fronts, as claimed by LALIGA, "For sports fans: Data-enhanced match coverage, personalized OTT streaming options such as camera angle selection in matches, augmented reality, virtual reality and 3-D replays; For rights holders, broadcasters and commercial partners: An enhanced OTT streaming platform that features personalized recommendations and enhanced experiences with relevant content, games and services; For venue managers: New innovations in security to improve stadium operations and unified in-stadium experiences through 5G."¹⁹

LALIGA was the world's first sports league which combined 'the experience of an international sporting organisation with deep technical expertise'. LALIGA Tech was an accumulation of the tech solutions first implemented within LALIGA and then made available

¹⁴ "LaLiga is a good case study as a business model", op.cit.

¹⁵ "Five years of LaLiga's international expansion with record growth", op.cit.

¹⁶ "What is LALIGA?", op.cit.

¹⁷ "LaLiga Tech introduces its suite of technology solutions, designed for the digital era of sports and entertainment", <https://newsletter.laliga.es/global-futbol/laliga-tech-introduces-its-suite-of-technology-solutions-designed-for-the-digital-era-of-sports-and-entertainment>, October 15th 2021

¹⁸ "Who is LaLiga Tech", <https://analysport.com/insights/who-is-laliga-tech/>, March 9th 2023

¹⁹ "LaLiga teams up with Microsoft to digitally transform football globally", <https://newsletter.laliga.es/global-futbol/laliga-teams-up-with-microsoft-to-digitally-transform-football-globally>, May 31st 2021

to the world to experience and implement.²⁰ It was another revenue stream for LALIGA.²¹ LALIGA's newsletter published in October 2021 introduced LALIGA Tech in the following manner, "Through a team of over 140 specialists that have designed solutions for LaLiga over the past seven years, it is now offering these solutions commercially to help accelerate the digital transformation of the industry. Available as managed services via the cloud, LaLiga Tech solutions are used to create new direct-to-consumer channels, enhance and protect content with real-time data and digitise key management processes. All solutions are interconnected under a single data-based ecosystem, delivering new insights that can be used to drive wider growth across the organisation." More details followed. While explaining the three main components (fan engagement, content enhancement, and competition management), Miguel Ángel Leal, CEO of LALIGA Tech said, "Sports and entertainment has an enormous opportunity to build on its emotional connection with fans by taking a data-led approach to understand fan behaviours and design modern, engaging and profitable experiences. Our products have been specifically created for the sector and are supported by the human resources that have turned LaLiga into a digital leader over recent years."²² (Exhibit III).

Exhibit III
LALIGA Tech: Main Components



Source: "LaLiga Tech introduces its suite of technology solutions, designed for the digital era of sports and entertainment", <https://newsletter.laliga.es/global-futbol/laliga-tech-introduces-its-suite-of-technology-solutions-designed-for-the-digital-era-of-sports-and-entertainment>, October 15th 2021

In addition to launching LALIGA Tech, the premier sports league announced two collaborations, one with World Padel Tour (WPT) and the other with Millicom. While the former was the premier professional padel circuit, the latter was the communication specialists. LALIGA Tech became the technology partner for WPT enabling it to reach wider global audience and newer fan experiences. LALIGA Tech had similar deals with big names in

²⁰ "LaLiga Tech introduces its suite of technology solutions, designed for the digital era of sports and entertainment", op.cit.

²¹ "What is LALIGA?", op.cit.

²² "LaLiga Tech introduces its suite of technology solutions, designed for the digital era of sports and entertainment", op.cit.

media and sports industry that included 'Dorna Sports, Moto GP, the Jupiler Pro League, Sky Mexico and the Royal Belgian Football Association'.²³

Incidentally, in an effort to improve fan engagement and as a part of overall technology driven growth strategy, LALIGA launched its mobile app in May 2023. LaLiga Xtra was launched in collaboration with Digital Virgo²⁴ and was available in regions like 'South America, Europe and MENA, including France, Belgium, Portugal, Argentina, and Morocco'. To put things in context and to understand the importance of mobile app, a revelation by Statista was worth noting. According to Statista, "The second screen use has become the norm for football fans when watching a match. 77% of people use their smartphone while watching TV, and 35% use applications. In this context, LaLiga Xtra provides the best content as a second screen to follow all content related to the live TV experience. Live results, advanced statistics, news, and much more can be accessed from a single point of reference."²⁵

In October 2023, in yet another step towards harnessing the power of data and analytics, LALIGA launched Mediacoach, a part of league's video and data analysis platform. Mediacoach was aimed at training unemployed coaches. As shared by LALIGA, "Elite coaches without a team will have access to regular training in the use of the Mediacoach platform and will be fully up to date when they join a team. This will shorten the adaptation period, increase the team's competitiveness, and keep the demands and intensity of the competitions high." Explaining the concept further, the LALIGA's official website stated, "Mediacoach is the competition's secret weapon for maintaining a high level of quality and competitiveness. LALIGA is the only major European football competition with a tool created in-house, specific to the competition and with uniform scope for all clubs. On a technical level, it collects a huge amount of data that is produced in real time during each match. This is thanks to the three tactical cameras and up to 16 different high-resolution fixed perimeter cameras for optical tracking that are installed in each LALIGA EA SPORTS and LALIGA HYPERMOTION stadium. The cameras track players, referees, and the ball across the pitch, recording each player's position with pinpoint accuracy at an astonishing speed of 25 times per second which generates more than 3,500,000 pieces of data per match, and translates to around 2,000 metrics per player. Data is revolutionising the football industry, with clubs using it for both match preparation and post-match analysis."²⁶

Coming back to LALIGA Tech, in 2022, Globant, an IT and software company, acquired a 51% majority stake in LALIGA Tech and in October 2023, LALIGA Tech became 'Sportian'. Sportian was an amalgamation of 'Globant's extensive track record in technology-driven business and industry transformation' and 'LaLiga's expertise as a leader in the leisure and entertainment sector'.²⁷ Martín Migoya, CEO of Globant, spoke on the collaboration, "With Sportian, we consolidate our strength in innovation and our commitment to the world of sports to reinvent the fan experience. We want to enable clients to enhance their connection with fans, both in live and digital settings." Tebas expressed similarly, "The technological commitment that LALIGA made in 2013 in the search for the solutions our industry needed, which laid the

²³ "LaLiga Tech introduces its suite of technology solutions, designed for the digital era of sports and entertainment", op.cit.

²⁴ One of the world's leading specialists in mobile payment via Telecom Operators' billing solutions.

²⁵ Briel Robert, "LaLiga launches international mobile app",

<https://www.broadbandtvnews.com/2023/05/30/laliga-launches-international-mobile-app/>, May 30th 2023

²⁶ "LALIGA launches data analysis pilot project for unemployed coaches", <https://www.laliga.com/en-GB/news/laliga-launches-data-analysis-pilot-project-for-unemployed-coaches>, October 5th 2023

²⁷ Ringrose Fergal, "Inside LaLiga: Digital transformation triggers new era with global outlook", <https://www.svgeurope.org/blog/headlines/inside-laliga-digital-transformation-triggers-new-era-with-global-outlook/>, October 5th 2023

groundwork for what Sportian is today, is now a unique value proposition for the sports and entertainment industry in the face of current and future challenges.”²⁸ José Luís Quintero (Quintero), Head of Customer Success, Sportian, explained the role of the company thus, “Basically what we are trying to do is leverage data and development from LaLiga and recreate products that can be positioned in the market and applied to other sports, not only football, and in other regions of the world. We can help with anything related to fan engagement, sport performance, gaming, competition apps, the future of venues and venue experience, business intelligence, and content creation.” Quintero added, “The fan is a very special customer, and we believe we can help to really put the fan in the middle of your business, with everything connected to offer the best experience to the fan and the possibility to better monetise this interaction.”²⁹

To understand the perspective, a study conducted in 2021 by Maru Group for the Variety Intelligence Platform on shifting fan behaviour revealed that, “In a splintered digital landscape in which traditional media models have been disrupted irrevocably, fans are now firmly in control as they access sports content on their terms – and strategies have had to adapt accordingly. Simultaneously, younger generations of sports fans are adopting seismic behavioral changes, such as favoring highlights over live coverage in certain sports.” Therefore, in yet another step to enhance fan engagement, LALIGA collaborated with WSC Sports, a technology provider, which provided league match highlights in a vertical format. Alfredo Bermejo (Bermejo), LALIGA's Digital Strategy Director, explained, “This delivery of engaging match snippets in a vertical format will resonate with those who have become accustomed to consuming social media content. Furthermore, the short-form approach enabled by WSC Sports is paying dividends by enhancing personalization for the end user.” Bermejo quoted few statistics to prove that LALIGA's new app launch and collaboration with WSC Sports was delivering along the desired lines, “In terms of figures, we are pretty excited with what we are seeing so far. We have increased the number of sessions that the fans are having on the app. The number of sessions per user has increased by more than 70%. Also, in terms of time spent on the platform we have seen an increase of more than 30% from one year to the next. Figures are promising and we are really happy with the result.” “We want to use to get that strategy in place and develop new audiences not just in terms of regions but also different ages and generations. Being able to create vertical videos is really, really key for that. We can tackle different regions and different demographics. We hope that WSC Sports can help us not just to rival the Premier League, but also the NBA or NFL”, he added. To expand LALIGA's overseas reach, Bermejo said, “We have ideas in mind such as automated commentators' translation or how to transform match footage into other kinds of images, and integrating augmented reality into traditional broadcasting. I think the most important thing is that we are aligning on the basis of how we make a better user experience so that when they consume sports, we are asking: how can we integrate different factors or customization into it? We did it with highlights, but why don't we have a different layer in terms of language? We have something that is produced in English and Spanish, so can we have that in 20 or 30 languages?”³⁰

In addition to the aforementioned, LALIGA was utilising other technological tools to improve decision making and other tasks (**Exhibit IV**). To enhance fan engagement, LALIGA improved its

²⁸ Prensa de Nota, “Globant and LALIGA Introduce Sportian, a Global Technology Company Reinventing the Sports and Entertainment Industry”, <https://www.laliga.com/en-GB/news/globant-and-laliga-introduce-sportian-a-global-technology-company-reinventing-the-sports-and-entertainment-industry>, October 2nd 2023

²⁹ “Inside LaLiga: Digital transformation triggers new era with global outlook”, op.cit.

³⁰ “Vertical Growth – How LALIGA is Enhancing Its Digital Portrait with WSC Sports”, <https://wsc-sports.com/blog/case-studies/vertical-growth-how-laliga-is-enhancing-its-digital-portrait-with-wsc-sports/>, December 6th 2023

audio-visual offering by employing '4K – HDR Production, aerial camera, 360° replays, Live 3D graphics, multi-screen, and acrobatic drones'.³¹

Exhibit IV
LALIGA and Technology

Technology	Usage
LALIGA+	An over-the-top (OTT) media platform offering free coverage of live and pre-recorded content, reports and interviews relating to the main competitions run by Spanish federations and leagues. LALIGA got better visibility along with other sporting events which otherwise were not promoted by traditional channels or had limited reach.
Anti-piracy	Through this technological tool LALIGA safeguarded its product and content from piracy. LALIGA provided its expertise in the area to other sports organisations (including Dorna Sports, Belgium's Jupiler Pro League and the Spanish Government's Ministry of Culture) too.
Mediacoach	This suite of advanced tools provided the 42 LALIGA EA SPORTS and LALIGA HYPERMOTION clubs with analysis and statistics to help them improve their performance levels in the competition. An advanced system of tracking cameras records and monitors player and ball movement aided a more in-depth study of the play and the technical-tactical and fitness aspects involved in a game.
Calendar Selector	This LALIGA-developed tool utilised machine learning and algorithms to suggest the kick-off times that will optimise TV audience and stadium attendance figures. The application, which was stored in the cloud, employed historical audience and attendance data plus a further 70 variables.
Sunlight Broadcasting Planning	This application forecasted the natural light conditions for each game. It indicated which areas of the stadium would be in the sunlight and the shade, which offered a preview of how the sun would impact on the TV image and on supporters, players, etc. and therefore helped when it came to scheduling kick-off times. Within this application, LaLiga used a 3D reconstruction of the stadiums.
Players App	A mobile app that provided players with privileged information relating to the pre-match and post-match, as well as exclusive lifestyle content (fashion, health, gastronomy...). The app provided players the ability to consult performance information from a match or the season as a whole, both individually and collectively. Also, the facial recognition software sent players the photos of themselves at the end of matches for use on social media.

Source: Compiled by the Author from – "What is LALIGA?",
<https://www.laliga.com/en-GB/pressroom/what-is-laliga>

However, despite integrating technology into soccer, it appeared that the EPL was a bigger entity than LALIGA. According to Moeed Rehman (Rehman), associated with the *Medium.com*, as of July 2023, "A jaw-dropping €1.293 billion has been spent on transfers, dwarfing La Liga's more modest €237 million. While the number of arrivals in La Liga is higher than the Premier League (208 vs. 161), the average transfer fee in La Liga is just one-eighth of its English

³¹ "What is LALIGA?", op.cit.

counterpart.” “The chasm between the two leagues becomes even more pronounced when we examine the spending per club. Premier League clubs, on average, shell out €64.69 million, while La Liga clubs lag behind at a mere €11.87 million. This staggering six-fold difference highlights the financial powerhouses of the Premier League and raises concerns for La Liga’s long-term sustainability”, he added. Rehman provided more food for thought, “The situation becomes intriguing when we compare income generated from player departures. In La Liga, the average income from player sales stands at €13.31 million, exceeding the money spent on transfers. However, in the Premier League, the picture is quite different, with clubs making an average of €30.77 million from player sales. This means that, on average, Premier League clubs pay twice as much for players as they earn from selling them.” Although, many EPL clubs had incurred losses due to overspending on player purchases and not earning enough from player sales. Amid this Rehman warned that, “When a majority of clubs in La Liga struggle financially, it raises red flags for the league’s future competitiveness. Diminished quality in the league may lead to dwindling interest, subsequently impacting revenue streams. Furthermore, the rich clubs are likely to take advantage of financially weaker counterparts, a trend that is already evident in recent player sales.” “The diverging financial trajectories of La Liga and the Premier League present a pressing concern for Spanish football. While giants like Barcelona and Real Madrid have stood strong, the majority of La Liga clubs face an uphill battle. As the disparity widens, it threatens the overall competitiveness of the league, affecting the financial well-being of all its participants. Addressing these financial imbalances and charting a sustainable course will be crucial to safeguarding the future of La Liga and its marquee clubs”, Rehman elaborated.³²

Rehman’s arguments notwithstanding, LALIGA was moving into the future with proper road map that included rebranding, new logo, investment in women football, expanding into untapped markets like India, and reaching out to more fans. Jose Antonio Cachaza (Cachaza), the LALIGA India MD, said in this connection, “A number of things have happened in the LALIGA in the last 10 years—how we went from being a local league to a world corporation with presence in 41 countries through 11 offices, how we went from managing just the economics of our league to being one of the biggest ecosystems in football with units such as LALIGA Business School, operations like LALIGA Genuine (a tournament with mentally-challenged players) or LALIGA Promises (a tournament of academies). It's much more than what happens on match days. We went for a total rebranding to represent these.” Acknowledging EPL’s supremacy, Cachaza remarked, “It won’t be easy to catch up with PL because they have been in the market quite a few years ahead of us and, thus, their relationship with the fans is older. But we work thinking we can.”³³ In view of Cachaza’s remarks, what else should LALIGA do to surpass EPL?

³² Rehman Moeed, “The Chilling Contrast between La Liga and the Premier League”, <https://medium.com/@moeedrehman50eme/the-chilling-contrast-between-la-liga-and-the-premier-league-aae0d0599eb7>, July 30th 2023

³³ Chanda Kathakali, “LALIGA rebrands for 2023-24 season, ropes in gaming platform EA as title sponsor”, <https://www.forbesindia.com/article/news/laliga-rebrands-for-202324-season-ropes-in-gaming-platform-ea-as-title-sponsor/85359/1>, June 5th 2023